KNOXVILLE AREA DSA

Rule on Officer Operating Procedures

PROPOSED, NOT YET ADOPTED

Knoxville Area Chapter of the Democratic Socialists of America

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“The Knoxville Area DSA seeks to facilitate the transition to a truly democratic and socialist society in which the means and resources of production are democratically and socially controlled.”

STATEMENT OF PURPOSE

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Section 1. Purpose and Authority

This Rule is adopted under Article XVIII, Section 1(c) of the bylaws and is the reserved Rule subject named in Article XVIII, Section 4(b): Officer Operating Procedures, governing the day-to-day operation of the offices. It carries out four delegations the bylaws make to it by name. Article IV, Section 8 commits to this Rule the full duties of each officer and the delegation, continuity-designation, leave-of-absence, attendance, spokesperson, and coalition-liaison mechanics of the offices. Article V, Section 4 commits to this Rule the notice periods and further procedure of Steering Committee meetings. Article VI, Section 6(d) commits to this Rule the procedures for verifying the identity of remote members, recognizing remote members to be heard, counting remote presence and votes, and restoring an interrupted remote channel. Article XI, Sections 2, 3, and 4 commit to this Rule the detail and mechanics of vacancy notice, interim appointment, and membership confirmation. Because the bylaws state only the core of each office in Article IV and delegate the full duty specifications here, this Rule is the Chapter's primary source for the officers' full duties and operating mechanics, and it states that content as its own law rather than as a restatement of bylaws text.

This Rule states how the officers of the Chapter carry out their offices from day to day: how Steering Committee meetings are noticed, agendized, and minuted, how decisions made between meetings are taken and recorded, how remote participation in Meetings of the Chapter is made to work, how an office is handed off when the officeholder changes, and how officers cover for one another. It is written for an officer who needs to know what to do and by when.

Two boundaries frame this Rule. It governs how the officers operate; it does not create the remote-participation right, which is fixed by Article VI, Section 6(b) as a guaranteed floor that binds the Steering Committee, and it does not govern accessibility accommodations for Meetings, which are governed by the Rule on Meeting Accessibility and Accommodations under Article VI, Section 6(c). This Rule operationalizes the bylaws. Under Article IV, Section 8 it does not and cannot reduce any duty, power, or accountability established in the bylaws, and it does not reduce any protection, threshold, or quorum set in the bylaws or in any Code. Where this Rule and a higher tier conflict, the higher tier controls under Article XVIII, Section 2.

Section 2. Definitions

For purposes of this Rule:

a) **Officer** means one of the five elected positions of the Chapter established by Article IV, Section 1: the two Co-Chairs, the Secretary, the Treasurer, and the Steward. Under Article V, Section 1, the term refers only to those five elected positions. It does not include subsidiary body

chairs or Harassment Grievance Officers, whose operating procedures are governed by the Rule on Subsidiary Body Operating Procedures and the Rule on Harassment Grievance Officer Operations respectively.

b) **Body** means the membership convened in a Meeting of the Chapter, or the Steering Committee, as the context requires.

c) **Records system** means the Chapter's canonical repository for records under the Information Security Code, Section 7. The platform is intentionally not named here so that it may change under that Code without amending this Rule.

d) **Messaging channel** means the secure-messaging channel approved under the Information Security Code, Section 5. It is a communication channel and not a records store.

e) **Decision register** means the permanent running record of significant Chapter decisions required by the Document Retention Code, Section 4(c), whose maintenance mechanics that Code commits to this Rule.

f) **Transition** means a change in the person holding an office, whether by election, resignation, removal under Article XI, Section 7 or Section 8, deemed resignation under Section 13 of this Rule, vacancy on loss of good standing under Article XI, Section 9, incapacity, or death, and whether the successor is an elected officer or an interim officer appointed under Article XI, Section 3.

Section 3. Application and General Standards

a) **Persons bound.** This Rule binds the officers of the Chapter. It binds an interim officer appointed under Article XI, Section 3 to the same extent as an elected officer for the duration of the appointment, and it binds a member carrying a delegated task, a continuity designation, or a coverage designation under this Rule to the extent of that task or designation.

b) **Officers act within the bylaws.** Nothing in this Rule enlarges an officer's authority. An officer exercises only the authority the bylaws give the office and remains subject to the limits in the bylaws, including the limit in Article XIV, Section 3 that no officer, acting alone, may commit the Chapter to any endorsement, solidarity action, or coalition action. An act in contravention of the bylaws, of any Code, of this Rule, or of any Policy is null and void under Article XIX, Section 2.

c) **Good standing and access.** An officer's access to Chapter accounts and the records system is governed by the Information Security Code. This Rule does not grant access; it assumes the access that Code provides.

Section 4. Non-Delegable Duties and Delegation

a) **The non-delegable core.** Tracking Article IV, Section 8, no officer may delegate, and nothing in this Rule or in any designation, coverage, or delegation under it permits an officer to delegate: the core accountability of the office; any signing or certifying duty, including financial signatory authority under Article XVI, Section 1 and the Secretary's written certification of the membership count and quorum numbers under Article VI, Section 5(c); or the officer's vote on any Chapter body.

b) **Delegable operational tasks.** An officer may delegate an operational task of the office to a member in good standing. The officer retains full responsibility and accountability for the delegated task, and the delegate acts under the officer's direction.

c) **Standing delegation of records maintenance.** The Secretary and the Steward may each maintain standing delegations of routine records-maintenance tasks, such as minute-taking assistance, registry upkeep, roster data entry, and engagement-record upkeep, to members in good standing without per-instance Steering Committee consent. Each standing delegation is recorded under subsection (e) and remains subject to the non-delegable core in subsection (a) and to the access controls of the Information Security Code.

d) **All other delegations require consent.** Any delegation other than a standing records-maintenance delegation under subsection (c) requires the consent of the Steering Committee.

e) **Recording.** Every delegation under this Section is recorded in the Steering Committee minutes or in the decision register, naming the task delegated, the member to whom it is delegated, the officer who remains accountable, and any time limit. Recording makes the consent, where required, and the officer's continuing accountability clear in the record.

Section 5. The Co-Chairs

a) **Presiding and executive coordination.** The Co-Chairs are the chief executive officers of the Chapter, serve jointly, and preside at Meetings of the Chapter and at Steering Committee meetings under Article IV, Section 4. They coordinate the work of the officers between meetings and see that the decisions of the membership and the Steering Committee are carried out.

b) **Organizing leadership.** The Co-Chairs lead the Chapter's political, legislative, labor, and coalition organizing, within the direction set by the membership and the Steering Committee.

c) **Reporting Steering Committee business to the membership.** The Co-Chairs see that the business of the Steering Committee is reported to each General Meeting, including any action taken without a meeting under Section 11, and that the minutes of Steering Committee meetings

are available to members through the inspection the Secretary administers under Article IV, Section 5 and the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure.

d) **Division of labor.** The two Co-Chairs may divide responsibilities between themselves by agreement. A division of labor does not reduce the authority or accountability of either Co-Chair. Either Co-Chair may exercise the routine executive authority of the office alone under Article IV, Section 4.

e) **Acts reserved to the Co-Chairs acting jointly.** An act the bylaws expressly reserve to the Co-Chairs acting jointly requires both Co-Chairs to concur. The acts so reserved include declaring an organizational emergency under Article XV, Section 1. If the Co-Chairs deadlock on such an act, the Steering Committee resolves the question by majority vote under Article IV, Section 4.

f) **Coalition contact.** The Co-Chairs are the Chapter's principal point of contact for allied organizations, subject to direction by the Steering Committee, to the spokesperson and liaison mechanics of Section 15, and to the limit that this contact carries no authority to commit the Chapter to any endorsement, coalition partnership, or formal alliance reserved to the membership or the Steering Committee under Article XIV.

Section 6. The Secretary

a) **Custody of governance records.** The Secretary is responsible for the Chapter's governance records under Article IV, Section 5, including the minutes of all Meetings of the Chapter and all Steering Committee meetings and the registries required by Article XVIII, Section 5. The Secretary keeps these records in the records system and maintains them as the Document Retention Code requires.

b) **Minutes.** The Secretary takes or arranges the taking of minutes at each Meeting of the Chapter and each Steering Committee meeting and prepares them for approval under Section 10. If the Secretary is absent, the presiding officer appoints a member to take minutes for that meeting.

c) **Member inspection administered under the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure.** The Secretary administers member inspection of governance and corporate records under Article IV, Section 5 and the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure, whose Section 9 governs the inspection procedure and its deadlines and whose classification and redaction provisions govern the confidentiality carve-outs. This Rule does not set the inspection procedure.

d) **Routing of roster and member-data requests.** A member request concerning the membership roster or member personal data is handled by the Steward under Article IV, Section 7 and the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure, Section 9(b), and the Secretary refers such

a request to the Steward. A request concerning governance or corporate records is handled by the Secretary under subsection (c).

e) **Communication-channel identification.** The Secretary, with the Steering Committee, identifies which tool approved under the Information Security Code, Section 5 serves each kind of officer communication: the messaging channel for routine real-time coordination, and the records system or Chapter email for any communication that is a record. This Rule selects no tool; tool selection is governed by the Information Security Code, and a tool may change under that Code without amending this Rule. The designation of official notice channels is governed by the Rule on Official Communication Channels under Article I, Section 4(f), not by this Rule.

f) **Written certification of the membership count and quorum numbers.** For each Meeting of the Chapter, the Secretary certifies in writing the number of members in good standing on the roster the Steward maintains, measured as of the first day of the calendar month in which notice of the Meeting is given, and the resulting ordinary and higher quorum numbers, as Article VI, Section 5(c) requires. The certification is a dated, signed writing stating the certified count and both quorum numbers; the Secretary delivers it in time for the certified count and quorum numbers to be published with the written notice of the Meeting, and keeps it in the records system. This certifying duty is non-delegable under Section 4(a). If the Secretary's position is vacant, the Steward certifies the count, and the further fallbacks of Article VI, Section 5(c) apply on their own terms.

g) **Backup for the Co-Chairs.** If neither Co-Chair is able to act, the Secretary temporarily assumes the responsibilities of the Co-Chairs under Article IV, Section 5 until a Co-Chair is able to act or the vacancy is filled under Article XI.

Section 7. The Treasurer

a) **Scope of this Section.** The Treasurer is responsible for the funds, financial records, financial reporting, and regulatory filings of the Chapter under Article IV, Section 6, and under Article IV, Section 8 the Treasurer's duties are governed also by the Financial Controls Code and the Compliance Code. Signatories, expenditure authorization, second-signature approval, reconciliation, and reimbursement are governed by the Financial Controls Code; the Treasurer carries all required state, federal, and National DSA regulatory filings under the Compliance Code and the Compliance Calendar. This Section sets only the reporting cadence and records practices not set by those Codes, and where it touches a subject either Code governs, that Code controls.

b) **Standing report to each General Meeting.** In addition to the reports the bylaws and the Financial Controls Code require, the Treasurer gives a brief financial report at each General Meeting, stating the balance of each Chapter fund, currently the Operations, Mutual Aid, and Electoral funds, income and expense since the last report, and any discrepancy identified in the most recent independent review under the Financial Controls Code, Section 10. This standing

report operationalizes, and reports more frequently than, the quarterly reporting floor of the Financial Controls Code, Section 13, and does not alter that Code.

c) **Budget and Convention reporting unchanged.** The Treasurer presents the proposed annual budget at the last General Meeting of the calendar year and distributes it as Article XVI, Section 3 requires, and presents the financial report for the fiscal year to date at the Annual Convention under Article VII, Section 3. This Rule does not alter those duties.

d) **Records practices.** The Treasurer keeps the financial records in the records system, retains them as the Document Retention Code requires, and conforms to the records and documentation requirements of the Financial Controls Code, Section 14.

Section 8. The Steward

a) **Role and boundary.** The Steward is the Chapter's lead internal organizing officer under Article IV, Section 7, responsible for member onboarding, integration, retention, and political education. Under the delegation of Article IV, Section 8, this Rule additionally assigns the Steward the Chapter's internal mobilization, carried in coordination with the Co-Chairs. The Steward does not handle harassment grievances, grievance intake, or the investigation of complaints, which belong to the Harassment Grievance Officers under Article XIII, and does not administer member discipline, which is governed by Article XII and the Discipline Code. This Rule sets no grievance or discipline mechanics for the Steward.

b) **Membership roster and National coordination.** The Steward maintains the Chapter membership roster in coordination with National DSA, consistent with the bylaws, applicable law, and the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure, as Article IV, Section 7 provides. The Steward reconciles the roster against National DSA membership data at least monthly, so that every count the Secretary certifies under Section 6(f) reflects the roster as most recently reconciled with National DSA.

c) **Count delivered for certification.** For each Meeting of the Chapter, the Steward delivers to the Secretary the number of members in good standing on the roster as most recently reconciled with National DSA, measured as of the first day of the calendar month in which notice of the Meeting is given, in time for the Secretary's written certification under Section 6(f) to be published with the written notice of the Meeting. If the Steward's position is vacant, the Secretary draws the count directly from the roster under Article IV, Section 7.

d) **Member privacy in roster and records.** The Steward protects the privacy of members in the roster and in member records, collects and holds no more member personal data than the organizing work requires, and handles roster and member-data requests under Article IV, Section 7 and the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure, with the statutory members' list

handling of its Section 5(d) and (e), the mailing address of record of its Section 7(d), and the routing of its Section 9(b).

e) **New-member contact.** The Steward, or a member organizer the Steward coordinates under a delegation recorded under Section 4, makes a welcome contact with each new member within two weeks of the member first appearing on the roster as reconciled under subsection (b).

f) **Engagement record.** The Steward keeps a simple record of member engagement sufficient to support onboarding, integration, retention, and the reports under subsection (g). The engagement record is a Chapter record kept in the records system, subject to the Information Security Code and the Document Retention Code.

g) **Reporting.** The Steward reports to each General Meeting on membership growth, retention, and internal mobilization, reports quarterly to the Steering Committee on any organizing benchmarks the Steering Committee or the membership adopts, and reports at the Annual Convention under Article VII, Section 3. This Rule does not set organizing benchmarks or targets.

Section 9. Registries and Governance Records Duties

a) **Registries.** The Secretary maintains the public registries of all current Codes, Rules, and Policies required by Article XVIII, Section 5, identifying every document by number, title, date of adoption, and date of last amendment. Members in good standing may request the full text of any listed document, and the Secretary provides it.

b) **Update timing.** The Secretary updates the relevant registry promptly after the adoption, amendment, or rescission of any Code, Rule, or Policy, and in no case later than thirty days after it, so that each registry reflects the current state of the governance hierarchy.

c) **Cross-reference table.** The Secretary maintains a table identifying every reference in the bylaws, Codes, Rules, and Policies to any other instrument or provision in the governance hierarchy, and updates it within the same thirty-day period after any amendment. The table is an aid to amendment drafting and to the Secretary's technical check under Article XX, Section 6(b), and the Secretary makes it available to any member in good standing on request. It is an Artifact under Article XVIII, Section 8: it binds no one, and it is corrected to the governing text if they ever differ.

d) **Registry mechanics deferred.** The format, numbering convention, repository location, publication cadence, version-control method, and distribution procedure for the registries and the instruments they list are governed by the Policy on Registry and Version Control, a Policy adopted under Article XVIII, Section 1(d). This Section fixes the Secretary's duty and timing under Article XVIII, Section 5; it does not set those mechanics.

e) **Membership-directed production of records.** When the membership at a General Meeting directs production of a record under the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure,

Section 6(b), the direction is moved and decided as ordinary business of the Meeting, by majority vote under Article VI, Section 1; placement of the item on the agenda and the notice of the Meeting remain governed by Article VI and the Rule on Meeting Operating Procedures, as Section 10(e) of this Rule provides. The Secretary records the direction in the minutes and the decision register, and the officer having custody of the record produces it as the direction states and as the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure provides, within the time the direction fixes or, if it fixes none, within the response clock of the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure, Section 9(c).

Section 10. Steering Committee Meetings, Agendas, and Minutes

a) **Cadence and call.** The Steering Committee meets at least monthly at the call of either Co-Chair or at the request of any three of its members, as Article V, Section 4 provides.

b) **Notice periods.** Under the delegation of Article V, Section 4, the notice periods are: at least four days written notice to the Steering Committee for a regular Steering Committee meeting, and at least twenty-four hours notice for a Steering Committee emergency meeting. A Steering Committee emergency meeting is a meeting of the Steering Committee on shortened notice; it is not a meeting of the whole Chapter and is distinct from an Emergency Meeting under Article VI, Section 3.

c) **Agenda.** A Co-Chair prepares and circulates the agenda for each regular Steering Committee meeting with or before the four-day notice under subsection (b). Any officer may add an item before the meeting, and any matter within the Steering Committee's authority may be raised at the meeting. The agenda-circulation requirement does not apply to a Steering Committee emergency meeting, whose notice states the matter to be taken up.

d) **Open meetings.** Steering Committee meetings are open to all members in good standing under Article V, Section 6, and the Steering Committee may go into executive session only as that Section provides. As a standing practice, the Steering Committee makes a remote channel available for its regular meetings so that members may attend and observe; this practice supports Article V, Section 6 and does not enlarge or create any bylaws right.

e) **General Meeting agendas not set here.** The Steering Committee sets the agenda of each General Meeting and communicates it by written notice at least seven days in advance under Article VI, Section 2. The timing of member petition items, and all other Meeting notice and agenda mechanics, are governed by Article VI and the Rule on Meeting Operating Procedures, not by this Rule.

f) **Minutes preparation.** The Secretary prepares draft minutes of each Meeting of the Chapter and each Steering Committee meeting and circulates them to the members of the body within

seven days of the meeting. Minutes record what the body did, consistent with the parliamentary authority adopted in Article XIX.

g) **Minutes approval.** The body approves the minutes of its previous meeting at its next meeting by unanimous consent: the presiding officer calls for corrections, incorporates corrections agreed without objection, and declares the minutes approved. A formal vote is taken only if a proposed correction is contested. This is the ordinary method under the parliamentary authority adopted in Article XIX.

h) **Minutes publication and custody.** The Secretary posts approved minutes to the members within three days of approval and keeps them in the records system as a permanent governance record under the Document Retention Code.

Section 11. Decisions Made Without a Meeting and the Decision Register

a) **The default is a meeting.** The Steering Committee ordinarily acts at a meeting noticed under Section 10. During a declared organizational emergency, the Steering Committee may conduct its business by electronic means on the terms of Article XV, Section 2, with each covered decision documented and submitted for ratification as that Section requires.

b) **Action without a meeting.** Outside a declared emergency, the Steering Committee may act without a meeting only by written consent under Tennessee Code Annotated section 48-58-202, consistent with its status as the Board of Directors under Article V, Section 2. Every officer then in office must consent to taking the action without a meeting; the action then requires the affirmative vote that would be required at a meeting; and the action is evidenced by one or more written consents describing the action taken, signed by each officer, and entered into the minutes and the corporate records. The action is effective when the last officer signs, unless the consent states a later date. If the officers do not all consent to act without a meeting, the matter waits for a noticed meeting.

c) **Messaging-channel votes.** A poll or vote conducted on the messaging channel is a binding act of the Steering Committee only if it meets the requirements of subsection (b). A messaging-channel exchange that does not meet subsection (b) is informal coordination and binds no one. An officer who initiates a messaging-channel vote intended to be binding promptly reduces it to a written consent under subsection (b).

d) **The decision register.** The Secretary maintains the decision register required by the Document Retention Code, Section 4(c). For each significant decision of the membership, the Steering Committee, or an officer acting under delegated authority, the register records the date, a short statement of what was decided, who decided it, the basis or authority for it, the

result of any vote, and a pointer to the minutes, financial record, or file holding the supporting material.

e) **Capture timing.** An officer who initiates or tallies a decision made without a meeting, including a written consent under subsection (b) and any binding messaging-channel vote, reports it to the Secretary within three days. The Secretary enters the decision in the register within seven days of the decision, and in every case before the messaging channel's automatic-deletion timer would remove the underlying messages under the Document Retention Code, Section 8, so that the decision is preserved in the register and the corporate records and does not rest only in a transitory channel. Decisions made in a meeting are captured into the register from the minutes.

f) **Form and custody.** The decision register is a single running record kept in the records system, permanent under the Document Retention Code, maintained consistently with the duty under Tennessee Code Annotated section 48-66-101(a) to keep a record of actions taken with or without a meeting.

Section 12. Remote Participation Procedures for Meetings of the Chapter

a) **The right, and the limit on this Section.** Article VI, Section 6(b) guarantees that every Meeting of the Chapter is a hybrid meeting offering remote participation and electronic voting by right, as a floor the Steering Committee may not condition, narrow, or withhold. This Section supplies the procedures Article VI, Section 6(d) commits to this Rule. Nothing in this Section, and no practice, tool choice, or officer decision under it, may convert the right under Article VI, Section 6(b) into discretionary access. The procedures exist to make the right effective; where any procedure in this Section and that right conflict, the right controls; and a failure of the Chapter or an officer to perform a procedure in this Section does not suspend, defeat, or diminish any member's exercise of the right.

b) **The remote channel.** For every Meeting of the Chapter, the Steering Committee provides a remote channel on a tool approved under the Information Security Code, Section 5, through which a member in good standing who does not attend in person may join, be identified, be heard, and vote. The joining instructions are published with the written notice of the Meeting, at no charge to the member, and the channel opens early enough before the call to order for remote members to complete sign-in under subsection (c).

c) **Identity verification.** The Secretary, in coordination with the Steward, verifies each remote participant against the membership roster at sign-in. Verification may be made by any reliable means proportionate to an in-person sign-in, including joining through instructions sent to the member's address of record, appearing under the member's name of record, or confirming

identity by voice or text against the roster. Verification is completed once at sign-in and is not repeated question by question, and it may not be more burdensome in substance than the sign-in asked of members attending in person. A verified remote member is present at the Meeting for all purposes of the bylaws. An unresolved identity question is decided by the Secretary against the roster, subject to appeal to the body, which decides by majority vote. Voter credentialing for elections, including the thirty-day eligibility requirement of Article IX, Section 9, is governed by the Code on Election Procedures and applies identically to in-person and remote voters.

d) **Recognition.** The presiding officer designates a remote-floor monitor for each Meeting, who may be an officer or a member in good standing. Remote members seek recognition through the channel's queue, hand-raise, or text function, or by voice, and the monitor reports the remote queue to the presiding officer. The presiding officer alternates recognition fairly between in-person and remote members. A remote member may make and second motions, debate, and raise a point of order with the same standing and effect as a member present in person.

e) **Quorum counting.** Verified remote members are recorded in the attendance record and counted toward quorum at the call to order and whenever attendance is measured under Article VI, Section 5(d), including for the higher-quorum checks that Section requires at the time of a vote.

f) **Vote counting.** A remote member votes by electronic means on the same questions, by the same recorded method, and with the same effect as a member present in person, as Article VI, Section 6(b) provides. On any counted vote, the tellers count the remote votes and the in-person votes and combine them before the presiding officer announces a result, and the minutes record the combined result. A vote by secret ballot, including a contested election under Article IX, Section 4, is conducted by a method that preserves ballot secrecy equally for remote and in-person voters, under the Code on Election Procedures where the vote is an election. Proxy voting is not permitted under Article VI, Section 6(a), and nothing in this Section is a proxy.

g) **Channel interruption and restoration.** If the remote channel fails or is materially degraded during a Meeting, the presiding officer pauses the pending business and the officers present attempt to restore the channel, using the fallback options of the approved tool, a replacement channel published to the same joining instructions, or both. While the channel is down, the Meeting may continue debate and may recess, adjourn, or fix the time to reconvene, but no vote on a substantive question may be taken and no quorum measurement may be made. A vote in progress when the channel failed is retaken after restoration. If the channel cannot be restored within thirty minutes, the Meeting recesses to a stated date and time or adjourns, and any recess to complete a noticed heightened action proceeds under Article VI, Section 5(d)(4). An action taken in violation of this subsection is null and void under Article XIX, Section 2.

h) **Relationship to accommodations.** Accessibility and participation support for Meetings, including interpretation, childcare, and venue accessibility, are governed by the Rule on Meeting Accessibility and Accommodations under Article VI, Section 6(c) and are not set by this Section.

Section 13. Attendance and Deemed Resignation

a) **Counted meetings.** For this Section, the counted meetings are regular Steering Committee meetings and General Meetings, including the Annual Convention. A Steering Committee emergency meeting, an Emergency Meeting, and a Special Meeting are not counted meetings. Attendance by remote participation is attendance.

b) **Excused absences.** An absence is excused, and is disregarded under this Section, if it results from illness, injury, caregiving, bereavement, an employment or education obligation, an approved leave of absence under Section 14, or other good cause communicated to a Co-Chair or the Secretary, in advance where practicable. Doubt about whether an absence is excused is resolved in the officer's favor.

c) **Referral by the other officers.** If an officer has been absent without excuse from three consecutive counted meetings, or has attended fewer than half of the counted meetings in any period of six months, the other officers may, by the affirmative vote of at least two thirds of the other officers then in office, refer the question of the officer's deemed resignation to the membership. The referral is in writing, states the absences relied on, and is delivered to the officer and to the Secretary.

d) **Membership confirmation.** The deemed-resignation question is placed before the membership at a General Meeting held within forty-five days of the referral, on at least seven days written notice to the membership and to the officer stating the question and the absences relied on. The officer has the right to respond in writing before the meeting and to be heard at it, in person or by remote participation under Article VI, Section 6(b). The membership decides by majority vote. If the membership confirms, the office is vacant at the close of that meeting and is filled under Article XI; if the membership declines, the attendance count under subsection (c) restarts from that meeting.

e) **Not a removal, and no reduction of Article XI.** A deemed resignation under this Section rests on the membership's confirmation vote and addresses only sustained unexcused absence. It is not a removal for cause, it may not be used to discipline an officer or to bypass the grounds, notice, higher quorum, supermajority, and hearing protections of Article XI, Sections 7 and 8, and it may not be based on any position or activity protected under Article III. Nothing in this Section reduces any protection of Article XI.

f) **Seat not vacant until confirmed.** The seat of an officer referred under subsection (c) is not a vacancy, and is not counted as a vacancy for any purpose, including the triggering conditions of

Article XV, Section 1, unless and until the membership confirms the deemed resignation under subsection (d).

Section 14. Continuity Designation and Leave of Absence

a) **Continuity designation.** Each officer maintains a written continuity designation, filed with the Secretary and noted in the decision register, naming another officer or a member in good standing to carry the operational tasks of the office during a short absence, or between the start of a vacancy and an interim appointment under Article XI, Section 3. The Secretary's own designation is filed with a Co-Chair.

b) **Operational limits of a designation.** A continuity designee carries operational tasks only. The designee never exercises a non-delegable duty under Section 4(a): no signing or certifying, no financial signatory authority, no certification of the membership count, and no officer vote. Where the bylaws fix a coverage rule, that rule controls over any designation: the remaining Co-Chair under Article XI, Section 1, the Secretary for both Co-Chairs under Article IV, Section 5, the Secretary for the Steward's membership records duties under Article IV, Section 7, and the Steward for the Secretary's quorum certification under Article VI, Section 5(c).

c) **Leave of absence.** The Steering Committee may grant an officer a leave of absence of up to ninety days for good cause, the officer concerned not voting, and may extend the leave once, for continuing good cause, by up to ninety further days. The grant, its length, and any extension are recorded in the minutes and the decision register, and the Secretary gives the membership written notice of the leave and of the coverage arrangements.

d) **No vacancy during leave.** An office whose holder is on an approved leave is not vacant, and is not counted as a vacancy for any purpose, including the triggering conditions of Article XV, Section 1. During the leave, the office's duties are carried under the coverage rules of Section 16 and the officer's continuity designation, subject to the limits of Section 4.

e) **Non-return.** If the officer does not resume the office at the end of the leave as extended, the other officers refer the question to the membership, and the referral, notice, hearing, confirmation vote, and effect proceed as for a deemed resignation under Section 13(d), (e), and (f).

Section 15. Spokesperson Status and Coalition Liaisons

a) **Default spokespersons.** The Co-Chairs are the default spokespersons of the Chapter. A spokesperson conveys the adopted positions of the Chapter and does not announce new positions or commitments.

b) **Designated spokespersons.** The Steering Committee may designate another officer or a member in good standing as a spokesperson for a stated matter and a limited time. The designation is recorded in the minutes or the decision register with its subject and duration, and it is revocable at any time by the Steering Committee or by majority vote of the membership.

c) **Coalition liaisons.** The Steering Committee may designate a standing coalition liaison to a named coalition or allied organization. A standing liaison designation is reported to the membership at the next General Meeting, which may confirm, decline, or replace the liaison by majority vote, and the membership may replace a liaison at any time. A designation lapses at the end of the officer year on July 31 unless renewed.

d) **Adopted positions only, and no commitment authority.** A spokesperson or liaison, whether default or designated, conveys only the positions the Chapter has adopted, and holds no authority to commit the Chapter to any endorsement, solidarity action, coalition partnership, or formal alliance. Article XIV governs those commitments, and Article XIV, Section 3 bars any officer acting alone from making them.

Section 16. Cross-Coverage During Absences

a) **Co-Chairs.** If a Co-Chair is absent or unable to act, the other Co-Chair carries the work of the office and may exercise the routine executive authority of the office alone under Article IV, Section 4; an act the bylaws expressly reserve to the Co-Chairs acting jointly still requires both to concur under Section 5(e) of this Rule. Only a vacancy confers more: if a Co-Chair position is vacant and not covered by a holdover under Article IV, Section 1, the remaining Co-Chair continues to serve with the authority of both Co-Chairs under Article XI, Section 1.

b) **Both Co-Chairs unavailable.** If neither Co-Chair is able to act, the Secretary temporarily assumes the responsibilities of the Co-Chairs under Article IV, Section 5.

c) **Steward records; Secretary certification.** If the Steward's position is vacant, the Secretary performs the membership records duties under Article IV, Section 7 until the vacancy is filled. If the Secretary's position is vacant, the Steward certifies the membership count and quorum numbers under Article VI, Section 5(c) until the vacancy is filled.

d) **Treasurer and Steward operational coverage.** If the Treasurer or the Steward is absent or unable to act for more than thirty consecutive days, the Steering Committee by majority vote designates another officer or a member in good standing to carry the operational duties of the office until the officer returns or the seat is filled. A designation under this subsection is operational coverage only, subject to Section 4(a). It is not an interim appointment, which is made under Article XI, Section 3, and it does not reach the Treasurer's signatory or filing duties, which are covered by the temporary-emergency-signatory procedure of the Financial Controls Code, Section 5 and the backup compliance officer under the Compliance Code, Section 3.

e) **Attendance and vacancies unaffected.** This Section addresses temporary coverage. It does not affect the attendance mechanics of Section 13 or the vacancy procedures of Article XI.

Section 17. Vacancy Notice, Interim Appointment, and Confirmation Mechanics

a) **Notice of vacancy.** On any officer vacancy, the Secretary provides written notice to the full membership within seven days, identifying the vacant office and the cause and date of the vacancy, as Article XI, Section 2 requires; if the Secretary's position is vacant, any other officer provides it. The notice also states how the vacancy will be filled under Article XI and invites eligible members to express interest to the Steering Committee. The Secretary reports the change to National DSA within thirty days under Article XI, Section 2 and the Compliance Code, Section 8, and the officer-slate report after an election proceeds under the Compliance Code, Section 8 on its own deadline.

b) **Interim appointment.** The Steering Committee makes the interim appointment within fourteen days of the vacancy under Article XI, Section 3, first confirming that the appointee meets the officer eligibility requirements of Article IV, Section 2 measured as of the appointment. The appointment vote is recorded in the minutes and the decision register, and the Secretary announces the appointment to the membership in writing, naming the interim officer, the office, and the confirmation vote to follow under Article XI, Section 4. The interim officer assumes the office immediately, and the handoff proceeds under Section 18. If the appointment is not made within fourteen days, the right of any five members to require a Special Meeting to fill the vacancy by direct election under Article XI, Section 3 operates on its own terms, and nothing in this Rule qualifies it.

c) **Membership confirmation.** The Secretary places the confirmation question on the agenda of a General Meeting held within forty-five days of the appointment or, if none is scheduled, the Steering Committee convenes a Special Meeting, in either case on at least seven days written notice identifying the interim officer and the confirmation question, as Article XI, Section 4 requires. The membership decides by majority vote, with remote participation and electronic voting available by right under Article VI. The Secretary records the result in the minutes and the decision register and reports it to National DSA under the Compliance Code, Section 8. If confirmation is denied, the interim's service ends at the close of the meeting and the office is filled as Article XI, Section 4 provides, with any floor election conducted under the Code on Election Procedures.

d) **Vacancies near the Annual Convention.** If the vacancy occurs within forty-five days before the Annual Convention, the interim appointment continues to the end of the term and the position is filled at the regular annual election, as Article XI, Section 5 provides, and no separate confirmation vote is scheduled.

Section 18. Officer Transitions and Handoff

a) **Application.** This Section applies on every transition as defined in Section 2(f).

b) **Handoff window.** The outgoing officer, or where the outgoing officer cannot act the remaining officers, completes the handoff of the office to the successor within thirty days of the transition. The handoff includes the transfer of the records, files, contacts, in-progress work, and pending obligations of the office, and a written summary of the state of the office, the matters in progress, and the upcoming deadlines.

c) **Shorter deadlines not extended.** The thirty-day window is the outer bound for the full handoff and extends no shorter deadline fixed elsewhere. In particular: signatory authority is updated with the Chapter's financial institutions within fourteen days of any change in signatories under the Financial Controls Code, Section 4; the Secretary gives notice of any vacancy within seven days under Article XI, Section 2; the officer-slate and officer-change reports to National DSA run on the deadlines of Article XI, Section 2 and the Compliance Code, Section 8; and the interim-appointment and confirmation deadlines of Article XI apply on their own terms.

d) **Credentials and access.** Continuity of credentials across a transition, removal of the departing officer's access, and rotation of any shared secret the departing officer could see are governed by the Information Security Code, Section 12, and are executed at every transition as that Code requires. This Rule does not alter those controls.

e) **Financial-records handoff.** On a change of Treasurer, the outgoing Treasurer delivers the financial records, the reconciliations, the supporting documents and confirmations for filings, and the Compliance Calendar to the successor within the window in subsection (b). The duplicate copies of filings and confirmations the Secretary retains under the Compliance Code, Section 3 remain available so that no filing or record depends on a single officer.

f) **No gap in coverage.** Until the handoff is complete, the outgoing officer where able, the interim officer appointed under Article XI, Section 3, the continuity designee under Section 14, and the covering officers under Section 16 see that the duties of the office continue to be performed.

Section 19. The Common Digital Platform for Member-to-Member Communication

a) **The platform.** The Chapter maintains a common digital platform through which members in good standing communicate with one another directly, across the whole membership, without officer intermediation. The Steward maintains the platform, with the Secretary, on a tool approved under the Information Security Code, Section 5.

b) **Additional to official notice channels.** The platform is additional to the Chapter's official notice channels. It does not replace, satisfy, or alter the official communication channels designated under Article I, Section 4(f) and the Rule on Official Communication Channels, a post on the platform is not written notice in any direction under Article I, Section 4(f), and no notice obligation of the Chapter or of any member is discharged or excused by the platform.

c) **Access.** Every member in good standing is entitled to access to the platform. Access is not conditioned on payment of voluntary Chapter dues, consistent with Article III, Section 5, and may not be withheld or restricted because of a member's caucus or faction activity, critique, or other activity protected under Article III, Section 4. Conduct on the platform remains subject to the Chapter Code of Conduct and the National DSA Code of Conduct, and any restriction of a member's access as discipline may be imposed only under Article XII.

Section 20. Internal Communications and Responsiveness

a) **Channels and capture.** Officers conduct Chapter communications on the tools approved under the Information Security Code, Section 5. The messaging channel is used for routine real-time coordination. A communication that is a record, or that records a decision, is captured into the records system or the decision register under Section 11 and is not left to expire on the messaging channel.

b) **Responsiveness.** An officer aims to respond to an internal request for action or decision within three business days. This is a standard of responsiveness, not a control, and it does not shorten any notice period or deadline set in the bylaws, in a Code, or elsewhere in this Rule.

Section 21. Relationship to the Bylaws and Other Governance Instruments

a) **Place in the hierarchy.** This Rule is subordinate to the bylaws and to every Code, and is superior to every Policy, under Article XVIII, Sections 1 and 2. No Policy may address a subject this Rule occupies, and the subject of this Rule is reserved to Rule tier by Article XVIII, Section 4(b).

b) **Finance and compliance.** Financial controls are governed by the Financial Controls Code, and the Chapter's regulatory, filing, and National-reporting duties are governed by the Compliance Code and the Compliance Calendar. Where this Rule touches either subject, that Code controls.

c) **Records instruments.** Retention periods, the permanence of minutes and the decision register, and legal holds are governed by the Document Retention Code. Tools, credentials, access control, and offboarding are governed by the Information Security Code. Records classification, disclosure, member inspection, and the statutory members-list handling are

governed by the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure. This Rule operationalizes officer practice around those instruments and does not reduce them.

d) **Neighboring Rules.** The internal workings of Branches, Standing Committees, Working Groups, and the Youth Section are governed by the Rule on Subsidiary Body Operating Procedures. The detailed conduct of the Annual Convention is governed by the Rule on Annual Convention Procedures. Meeting notice and agenda timing, petition-item placement, and the notice and conduct of Emergency and Special Meetings are governed by the Rule on Meeting Operating Procedures. Accessibility and participation support are governed by the Rule on Meeting Accessibility and Accommodations. Official notice channels and the official Chapter email address are governed by the Rule on Official Communication Channels.

e) **Elections, grievances, and discipline.** Election conduct and credentialing are governed by the Code on Election Procedures. Grievances are governed by Article XIII, the Unified Grievance Policy, and the Rule on Harassment Grievance Officer Operations, and member discipline by Article XII and the Discipline Code. No officer procedure in this Rule reaches those subjects.

f) **Membership authority preserved.** Nothing in this Rule limits the authority of the membership under Article VI, Section 1 to direct any matter within the membership's authority.

Section 22. Review and Amendment

a) **Amendment.** This Rule may be amended or rescinded by majority vote of the membership at any General Meeting on seven days written notice, under Article XVIII, Section 1(c), subject to the reservation of its subject to Rule tier at Article XVIII, Section 4(b).

b) **Periodic review.** The Steering Committee reviews this Rule at least once each fiscal year, together with the Financial Controls Code and the Information Security Code, and recommends to the membership any change the Chapter's experience shows is needed.